

Southeastern Asia and India



THE CLIMATE IN INDIA is dominated by the seasonal changes caused by the monsoon winds. They bring torrential rain and violent storms in summer. Dry, cooler weather occurs in winter. There are many types of habitats in India, from mangrove swamps along the coasts, to open plains, scrubland, and broadleaved forests inland. India is a meeting place for animals from the Far East and the West. As a result, many Indian animals, such as the elephant and rhinoceros, are similar to those found in southeastern Asia or Africa.

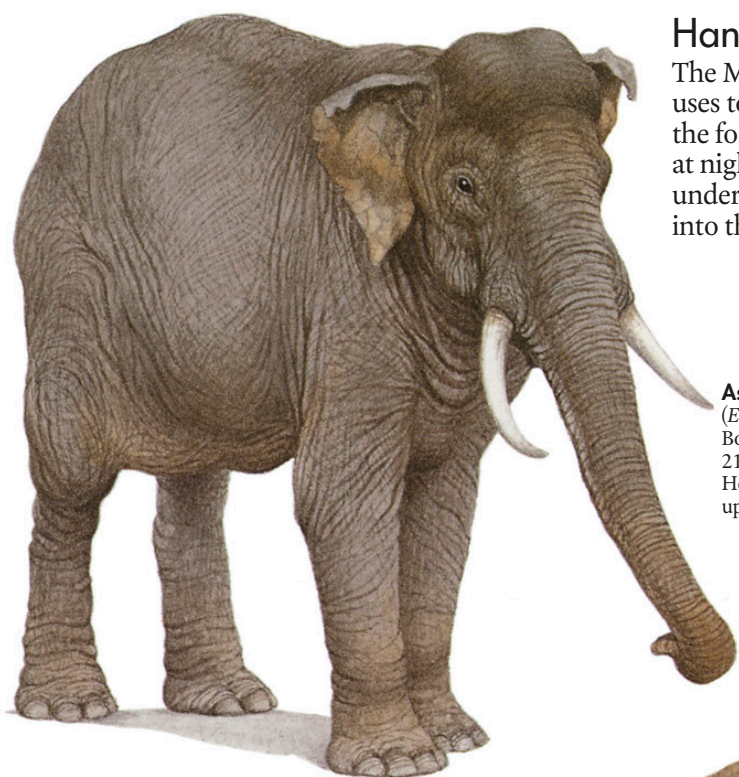
The climate of southeastern Asia is generally warm and humid year round, and tropical rainforests flourish. Many animals live high up in the canopy of the forest where there is more light, water, and food. These rainforests are also home to a huge number of insects. Much of the rainforest has been cleared to make way for farmland and houses, putting animals in danger of extinction. Some of the rarest animals, such as the Javan rhinoceros, survive only in remote parts of the Indonesian islands.



Malayan tapir (*Tapirus indicus*)
Height at shoulder:
up to 4 ft 3 in (1.3 m)
Head and body: up to
9 ft 10 in (3 m)

Handy nose

The Malayan tapir has a long nose that it uses to pull shoots, buds, and fruits from the forest plants. The tapir comes out mainly at night, moving quickly through the forest undergrowth. A good swimmer, it may plunge into the water to escape from enemies.

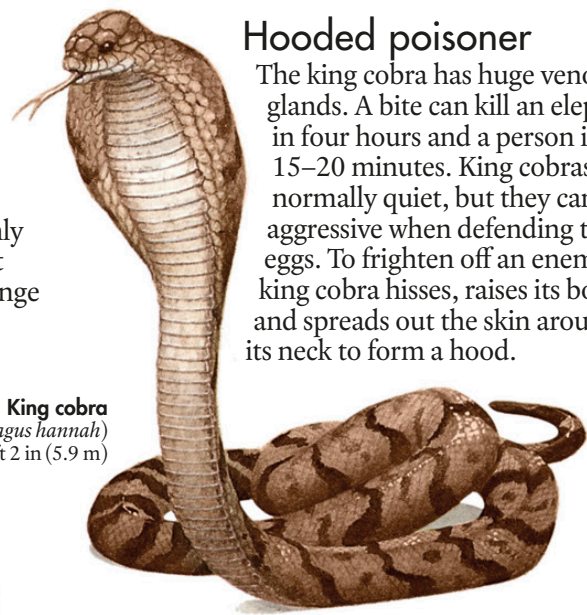


Asian elephant (*Elephas maximus*)
Body length: up to
21 ft (6.4 m)
Height at shoulder:
up to 11 ft 1 in (3.4 m)

Spot the difference

The Asian elephant is similar to its African relative, but has smaller ears, a more humped back, and four nails on each back foot instead of three. Only some of the males have tusks, and these are usually shorter than the tusks of African elephants. Asian elephants live in herds made up of closely related individuals, led by an elderly female.

Indian rhinoceros (*Rhinoceros unicornis*)
Body length: up to 11 ft 4 in (3.5 m)
Height at shoulder: up to 6 ft 7 in (2 m)



King cobra (*Ophiophagus hannah*)
Length: up to 19 ft 2 in (5.9 m)

Hooded poisoner

The king cobra has huge venom glands. A bite can kill an elephant in four hours and a person in just 15–20 minutes. King cobras are normally quiet, but they can be aggressive when defending their eggs. To frighten off an enemy, the king cobra hisses, raises its body, and spreads out the skin around its neck to form a hood.

Atlas moth (*Attacus atlas*)
Wingspan: up to
12 in (30 cm)



Wings with eyes

The spots on the wings of the atlas moth may help protect it from enemies—birds, for instance, often peck at the “eyes” on its wings instead of the moth’s real eyes. The male has large, feathery antennae, which pick up the scent given off by females that are ready to mate.

Armor plating

The Indian rhinoceros looks as if it is wearing a suit of armor because it has thick skin with deep folds at the joints. Its skin protects it from spiky forest plants. The rhinoceros likes to be near water because it often takes baths. It has been hunted for its horn, which is used in Chinese medicine, and is now classed as a vulnerable species.